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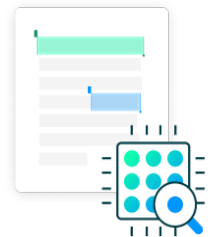
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Motivation Letter

Over the past six years of economics training, I have mastered analytical tools ranging from individual decisions to macro economic fluctuations and cultivated the thinking mind of adopting utility functions and equilibrium points to interpret the world. However, with more in-depth research, I discovered the limitation of sole economic perspective. Real-world problems are often deeply intertwined and simple economic models are inadequate in explaining the political maneuvering, historical context, and irrational cultural factors underlying national behaviors. Attending Professor Qian Chengdan's lecture on Area Studies was an eye-opener. His incisive analysis of Lancang-Mekong Cooperation made me realize that the issue is far more complex than just water allocation or trade complementarity. Instead, it is a complex aggregate involving six countries, divergent historical memories, and intricate geopolitics. Therefore, I aspire to step out of the singular perspective of economics to explore those complex variables and to dig into the logic behind national decision-making.

While I am pursuing a shift in perspective, the rigorous logic and quantitative skills I gained from economics remain my most valuable assets. During my undergraduate studies, I maintained excellent grades in courses such as *Econometrics*, *Python Programming*, and *Application of ArcGIS to the Economic Research*, laying a solid foundation for data processing. Subsequently, when pursuing my Master's in Economics at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (UIUC), I specialized in advanced quantitative methods, and earned A+ grades in core courses like Time Series Analysis, Machine Learning, and Game Theory. Ultimately, I completed my master's degree with straight A's and was awarded the Certificate of Academic Excellence.

This rigorous training is fully reflected in my research on "The Impact of Cap-and-Trade Programs on Air Quality", during which I utilized the Difference-in-Differences (DID) method to evaluate policy differences between California and New Mexico. As the core researcher, I tackled complex model construction and omitted variable bias by introducing various control variables to eliminate endogeneity. Although the final results showed no statistically significant effect, this gave me a much deeper insight into empirical research: in policy evaluation, insignificance reveals the frictions and lags within policy transmission mechanisms.

To bridge the gap in political perspective, I took courses in *International Conflict and China's Diplomacy*, through which I explored world dynamics from perspectives such as energy security and international conflicts. The instructor used Huawei and Tesla as examples to vividly illustrate the interaction between corporate and international relations. I also systematically studied modern Chinese history and read classic works such as *The Old Regime and the Revolution* and *The Rise of the Western World*, gaining insight into the logic of national development from a historical perspective. During my master's studies, I read *Behavioral Game Theory* in a game theory course and discovered that signaling games could be applied to the study of policy lobbying. It was in this way that the disciplinary barriers I had once perceived began to break down.

After graduating with my master's degree, my internship at the Institute of Area Studies at Renmin University of China became a decisive moment in my transition. I was responsible for writing

news drafts on European studies, and in the meantime gained deep exposure to frontier views on “German De-risking” and “China-EU Relations.” I discovered that compared to the relatively structurally fixed China-US relations, the internal political ecology of Europe is full of dynamic changes and multi-party games, which ignited my interest in delving deeper into European issues.

More importantly, while co-authoring the article “Area Studies in the Age of Artificial Intelligence”, I experienced an intellectual epiphany. Initially, faced with abstract sociological concepts like Social Combustion Theory, I, accustomed to quantitative thinking, felt ill at ease. It wasn't until I tried to deconstruct it with economic thinking: viewing it as a special production function, where the combustible material is the capital and labor, the combustion improver is the public opinion environment, and the output is the probability of social unrest. In that moment, I saw the possibility of merging two worlds and realized that combining quantitative thinking with qualitative political analysis would be my unique academic path, capable of injecting new vitality into regional research.

Driven by my passion for research, I plan to pursue a doctoral degree and aspire to work in academia. My internship experience made me aware of the arduousness and monotony of academic work, yet I still enjoy the process of peeling back the layers through logic and evidence to approach the truth. The International Relations (MA) of Leiden University attracts my attention for its unique humanities-based approach to international relations. In addition, your interdisciplinary integration of politics with historiographical, cultural, and area studies teaching and research aligns well with my academic pursuits in interpreting the world through intellectual history and the roots of cultural conflict, and understanding the current geopolitical landscape from a long historical perspective. I also value your broad, flexible curriculum and five specialisations, among which I prefer Global Order in Historical Perspective to examine how the global order has evolved over time. Leiden University's IR program places great emphasis on history and culture, which are indispensable foundations for in-depth area studies. If fortunate enough to be admitted, I plan to conduct in-depth research in it and participate in field visits and internship programs to hone practical skills. After graduation, I aim to pursue a Ph.D. in Area Studies and in the long term, I intend to join a research institute, where I can develop deep expertise to grow into an expert.